

Empty, Not Nothing: Nagarjuna's Middle Way Between Being and Non-Being

An original lesson plan inspired by **Douglas Berger's** the Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Nagarjuna. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Douglas Berger. Explore the original course: <https://iep.utm.edu/nagarjun/>

GRADE LEVEL

Undergraduate / Graduate Seminar

DURATION

70 minutes

TOPICS

Eastern Philosophy

“Nagarjuna argues that literally nothing — not causation, not motion, not even the self — possesses inherent, independent existence, yet he insists this doesn't collapse into nihilism. How can everything be 'empty' and still function, conventionally, exactly as it appears to?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Nagarjuna's central concept of emptiness (sunyata) as the absence of inherent, independent existence (svabhava), distinguishing it carefully from the nihilist claim that nothing exists at all.
- Reconstruct Nagarjuna's argument that emptiness is equivalent to, and follows from, dependent origination (pratityasamutpada) — the doctrine that all phenomena arise only in dependence on other conditions.
- Analyze the two truths doctrine (conventional truth and ultimate truth) and evaluate whether it successfully lets Nagarjuna affirm ordinary, everyday reality while denying that anything has inherent existence.

Materials Needed

- Excerpt packet with selected verses from the Mulamadhyamakakarika, including passages on causation/motion and the key verse identifying emptiness with dependent origination (chapter 24)
- Two truths diagram handout (conventional vs. ultimate truth)
- Tetralemma (catuskoti) explainer handout with a worked example
- Whiteboard for building the emptiness/dependent-origination argument chart

Lesson Procedure

Framing: Is 'Empty' the Same as 'Nothing'?

10 min

Open by posing the core tension directly: Nagarjuna says everything — chariots, causes, selves — lacks any inherent essence of its own, yet insists this is not the same as saying nothing exists. Ask the seminar to generate an initial hypothesis, individually, for how 'lacking inherent existence' could be different from 'not existing at all,' to be revisited later in the session.

Mini-Lecture: Svabhava and the Critique of Causation

20 min

Introduce svabhava (inherent, independent, self-sufficient existence) as the target of Nagarjuna's critique, and walk through his method in the Mulamadhyamakakarika of examining ordinary categories — causation, motion, the self, even the Buddha's own teaching — and showing that none of them can be coherently said to possess svabhava once analyzed carefully (for instance, his argument that a cause cannot produce an effect that already exists, nor one that doesn't yet exist in any sense, undermining a straightforward notion of independent causal power). Emphasize that Nagarjuna is not denying that things happen, only that they happen with any self-sufficient essence behind them.

Seminar Close Reading: Emptiness as Dependent Origination

20 min

Facilitate close reading of the key verse identifying emptiness with dependent origination: to say something is empty is just another way of saying it arises only in dependence on other conditions, and has no existence apart from that web of dependence. Push the seminar to work through why this move is central to Nagarjuna's response to the nihilism worry — if emptiness simply meant 'nothing exists,' dependent origination (which clearly does describe how things arise and function) would be meaningless, but Nagarjuna treats the two as two ways of saying the same thing.

Discussion: The Two Truths and the Tetralemma

15 min

Introduce the two truths doctrine: conventional truth, under which ordinary claims about chariots, causes, and persons function perfectly well for everyday and even scientific purposes, and ultimate truth, under which none of these things is found to have inherent existence upon careful analysis. Introduce the tetralemma (catuskoti) as Nagarjuna's characteristic way of refusing all four standard logical options about a thing (it exists, it doesn't exist, it both exists and doesn't, it neither exists nor doesn't) when applied to claims about inherent existence. Ask the seminar whether the two truths doctrine is a genuine philosophical solution or a convenient way to have things both ways.

Closure: Revisiting Emptiness vs. Nihilism

5 min

Return to the opening question. Ask each participant to state, in one or two sentences, whether they now find Nagarjuna's distinction between emptiness and nihilism successful, and to briefly note what they see as the strongest remaining objection to it.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If nothing has inherent existence, what work is left for the word 'exists' to do at all when Nagarjuna still says conventional things function and arise?

- 2 Is the two truths doctrine a genuine philosophical resolution to the tension between emptiness and everyday experience, or a way of avoiding the tension by keeping the two levels permanently separate from each other?
- 3 Nagarjuna's argument against causation claims a cause can't produce an effect that already exists or one that doesn't exist in any sense — is this a genuine logical problem with causation, or does it rely on an overly narrow idea of what 'existing' must mean?
- 4 Does the tetralemma's refusal of all four standard logical options (exists, doesn't exist, both, neither) represent a real alternative to ordinary logic, or is Nagarjuna using it rhetorically to gesture at something beyond conceptual thought altogether?
- 5 If emptiness applies to literally everything, including Nagarjuna's own arguments and the concept of emptiness itself, does his position risk undermining its own claims to be true?

Assessment

Students write a seminar paper (2-3 pages) reconstructing Nagarjuna's identification of emptiness with dependent origination, explaining specifically how this identification is meant to block the charge of nihilism, and evaluating whether the two truths doctrine successfully preserves the everyday functioning of conventional reality while denying inherent existence at the ultimate level, with direct citation of the assigned verses.

Extension Activity

Have students find a modern scientific or philosophical account of causation or identity (for instance, in physics or cognitive science) that similarly denies any 'essential core' to objects or selves, and write a short comparison of how that account's motivations and conclusions resemble or differ from Nagarjuna's doctrine of emptiness.

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